A Soldier's Thoughts

By Zachary Scott-Singley

April 29, 2005

I have a confession to make. My platoon and I have had over 192 confirmed kills during our first deployment here to Baghdad. We targeted people and then they just disappeared. Why? They were going to kill me. I had my orders and they had theirs. We were mortal enemies because we were told that we were. There are some who would tell me to not think about what I had to do, or it will drive you insane.

But I can't help but think about it.

INTRODUCTION

Zachary Scott-Singley was a sergeant in the 3rd Infantry Division, stationed in Tikrit, Iraq. In this selection, Zachary shares his thoughts and feelings, helping us to better understand our soldiers upon their return to civilian life.

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The enemy was men like me. Some of them were even conscripted into military service. What made them fight? Were they more scared of their leader than of us? What has become of their families? How could I forget or not think about all that I have done? Should I wash my hands of it all like Pontius Pilate? I think not.

My choices have been made, my actions irreversible. So live I will, for we were the victors, right? The ones who survived. It is our victory, and our burden to carry, and I bear it with pride and with the greatest of remorse. Do you think that there is a special place in hell for people like me? Or will God judge me to have been a man of honor and duty?

When they told us how many we had killed my first thought was pride. Pride for such a high number. How does one feel pride for killing? Two years later and my thoughts are changed, transformed if you will. Those were just numbers so long ago when I first heard them. Now, however, I know that they were men with families like mine. It is crazy that we humans can be so destructive. There are people out there lining up to

become martyrs, to kill themselves in order to kill others, and yet you still have people who fight tooth and nail to live for just one more minute longer. We are an oxymoron, humanity that is. What makes someone look down the sights of a rifle to take aim on a fellow human being? What does it take to pull the trigger? I have done those things. I have done them and would do it again if it meant returning to my wife and children again. Some of you may think that I am a beast and you are probably right. I am. I will kill, I will take aim and fire, I will call fire upon you from afar with rockets and bombs or anything I can get my hands on if it means that I will see my family one more time.

But I will also choose to dwell on and live with my choices. I chose to enlist as a soldier. My time has been served and now it is becoming overtime, but I won't just run away. As much as I would love to just be done (and rightly so now that I have been involuntarily extended). One thing is all I ask of you. I ask that you not judge me. Let me be my own judge, for my judgment is harsher than any you could give me anyway. For I will always have

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those memories to remind me of what I have done and what I am. Please know that I pray for peace every day, that and to see my family again.

May 4, 2005

It was still dark. I got dressed in that darkness and got in the truck. I was going to go line the truck up in preparation for the raid we were about to go on. The targets were three houses where RPG attacks had come from a few days prior. Sitting there in that darkness listening to the briefing on how we were to execute the mission, I let my mind wander and said a prayer. "Just one more day, God, let me live one more day." It was the same prayer I said every day because every day I did the same thing. I left the base. With a small team I would go out each day on different missions. I was their translator.

There were different people to meet each day. There were some who would kill you if they could. They would look at you and you could see the hate in their eyes. I also met with people who would have given me

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everything they owned. People that were so thankful to us because we had rid them of Saddam.

The raid began without a hitch. I was talking to an Iraqi woman, checking to see if her story correlated with what the detained men had said. I heard gunfire. It was automatic gunfire. I saw a soldier amongst the others who was still aiming his M249 at a black truck off in the distance. His was the weapon I had heard.

I ran up near his position and overheard the captain asking why this soldier had opened fire. The soldier said he was sure he had seen a man holding an AK-47 in the back of the black truck.

I was among the four selected to go and see what was up with that truck.

We were out of breath when we got there. There was a group of four Iraqis walking toward us from the truck. They were carrying a body. When I saw this I ran forward and began to speak in Arabic to the man holding the body, but I couldn't say a word.

There in the arms of one of the men I saw a small boy (no more than three years old). His head was cocked

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back at the wrong angle and there was blood. So much blood. How could all that blood be from that small boy? I heard crying too. All of the Iraqi men standing there were crying and sobbing and asking me WHY? Someone behind me started screaming for a medic. It was the young soldier who had fired his weapon. He screamed and screamed for a medic until his voice was hoarse and a medic came to tell us what I already knew. The boy was dead. I was so numb.

I stood there looking at that little child, someone's child (just like mine), and seeing how red the clean white shirt of the man holding the boy was turning. It was then that I realized that I had been speaking to them, speaking in a voice that sounded so very far away. I heard my voice telling them (in Arabic) how sorry we were. My mouth was saying this but all my mind could focus on was the hole in the child's head. The white shirt covered in bright red blood. Every color was so bright.

I can still see it all to this very day. The raid was over, there were no weapons to be found, and we had accomplished nothing except killing a child of some

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unknowing mother. Not wanting to leave yet, I stayed as long as I could, talking to the man holding the child. I couldn't leave because I needed to know who they were. I wanted to remember. The man was the brother of the child's father. He was the boy's uncle, and he was watching him for his father who had gone to the market. They were carpenters and the soldier who had fired upon the truck had seen someone holding a piece of wood and standing in the truck bed.

Before I left to go back to our base I saw the young soldier who had killed the boy. His eyes were unfocused and he was just standing there, staring off into the distance. My hand went to my canteen and I took a drink of water. That soldier looked so lost, so I offered him a drink from my canteen. In a hoarse voice he quietly thanked me and then gave me such a thankful look, like I had given him gold.

Later that day those of us who had been selected to go inspect the black truck were filling reports out about what we had witnessed for the investigation. The captain who had led the raid entered the room we were

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in and you could see that he was angry. He said, "Well this is just great! Now we have to go and give that family bags of money to shut them up." I wanted to kill him. I sat there trembling with my rage. Some family had just lost their beautiful baby boy and this man, this COMMISSIONED OFFICER in the United States Army is worried about trying to pay off the family's grief and sorrow. He must not have been a father, otherwise he would know that money doesn't even come close. . . .I wanted to use my bare hands to kill him, but instead I just sat there and waited until the investigating officer called me into his office.

To this day I still think about that raid, that family, that boy. I wonder if they are making attacks on us now. I would be. If someone took the life of my son or my daughter nothing other than my own death would stop me from killing that person. I still cry too. I cry when the memory hits me. I cry when I think of how very far away I am from my family who needs me. I am not there just like the boy's father wasn't there. I pray every day for my family's safety and just that I was

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with them. I have served my time, I have my nightmares, I have enough blood on my hands.

June 17, 2005

I can't stop thinking about what a major said to me the other day: "The whole country of Iraq, every man, woman, and child . . . Kill every one of them and it still won't be worth one American's life."

So often I hear, "I'm gonna go shoot me some Hajji." The soldiers who say these things speak as if the Iraqi people were some kind of animal to be hunted, but if you look at the statistics most of those killed are civilians not foreign fighters.

There are things like the value of a human life or the value of an entire nation that has been kicked so many times by tyrants that it may look downtrodden and useless but under it all there is the beauty of LIFE.

October 27, 2005

What is the human condition? Here in Iraq we fight terrorists and insurgents. We give them names

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(hajji, towelhead, raghead) to peel away their humanity. We focus only on the horrible things that have happened so that we can bring ourselves to kill, but in doing so we too become changed. No longer do we fit in when we get home. We become outsiders and misfits amongst our own families and distance ourselves as others too distance themselves from us.

You can't let others know the things you have done because they would never understand and it would only serve to make us even more alone.

We must build as well. Walls are our specialty, so we build them thick and high around ourselves. These walls shut out all the pain and hurt we feel when others can't seem to understand why we are the way we are, or when they judge and condemn us as if they were God himself. These walls don't just keep those things out, but they serve to keep so much in as well. All of it, the guilt, the pain, and the fears we have can be kept deep inside where nobody will have to see them except ourselves.

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That is OK though, because from there we can learn one last and important skill, that of the beast tamer. We learn tricks to keep the beast inside so that nobody will ever have to see how much of a monster we have become. In doing so we can continue our walk through life. That is the soldier's cost of war, and it is ours to bear alone until the end.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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